

Income, Food, Housing

POSC 459 — Social Welfare Politics and Policy

Week 7 · Monday, October 5

Howard, Who Cares, chs. 5–7

Today

1. Your households: A, B, and C
2. **Income:** built for workers
3. **Food:** built on need
4. **Housing:** built on a waiting list
5. The source and claims memo, due Friday

This week and next

Wed 10/7	Medicaid and the states. Grogan and Andrews; Howard (2007) ch. 8
Fri 10/9	Source and claims memo due 11:59 p.m.
Mon 10/12	Midterm review
Wed 10/14	Midterm , in class. Bring a blue book

Three households, two screeners

	Household	Income	Rent
A	Single parent, kids 4 and 9	\$27,300	\$1,800
B	Married couple, child 6	\$40,000	\$2,200
C	CSUF student, 21, no kids	\$10,296	\$900

What did yours get?

What the screeners said

	EITC (tax year 2025)	CalFresh
A	\$6,315	May qualify. About \$557 a month
B	\$2,801	May qualify. About \$304 a month
C	\$0	May qualify. Up to \$306 a month

Dollar estimates for CalFresh are mine. The screener only says "may qualify."

What the IRS told you

Households A and B: **17** of you ran the EITC Assistant.

Screenener result	Households
The right credit: \$6,315 or \$2,801	3
"Income is over the limit": \$0	11
A small credit: \$910 or \$1,131	3

14 of 17 eligible households left with the wrong answer.

The question that decided it

Screenener	Deciding questions	Never asked
IRS	Children? Age 25 to 64? Earned income?	Rent. Need
Robin	Household size? Monthly income?	Work. School

Howard's four questions

Who qualifies?

Who pays?

Who delivers?

Is it enough?

Howard 2023, drawing on Joan Tronto's phases of care

Income: start with a job

- **8 million** poor Americans worked in 2018
- More than **two-thirds** of them part-time
- Nearly **one-third** of the labor force: under \$12 an hour
- A typical payday loan: **382%** a year

Howard 2023, ch. 5

The three programs aimed at the poor

	Who	Reach	Benefit
TANF	Very poor families with children	3 million people	Under half the poverty line
EITC	Low-wage workers, mostly parents	27.5 million tax filers	About \$3,200, family of four
SSI	Aged, blind, disabled poor	9 million	About \$550 a month

Howard 2023, ch. 5. Figures for 2017–2019

TANF depends on your state

Income ceiling for a family of three, per month (2018):

Alabama	Michigan	Typical state	Rhode Island
\$268	\$815	\$840	\$1,277

Poor families on cash welfare: **68%** in 1996 → **22%** in 2018

Howard 2023, ch. 5

The heavy lifting is social insurance

	Lifted out of poverty
Social Security	18 million older Americans
TANF	Fewer than 250,000 children

Child poverty **16.2%** · elderly poverty **9.7%** (official, 2018)

Howard 2023, ch. 5

Income: who pays?

Program type	Paid by
Means-tested (TANF, EITC, SSI)	Income taxes. Mostly the affluent
Social insurance	Payroll taxes. Every worker

"The rich take care of the poor, whether they intend to or not."

Income, in one line

Cash follows work.

Not working, no children, no work history: very little

Food: need, not work

SNAP (2019): **36 million** people a month · about **\$1.40 a meal**

Who gets SNAP	
Children	44%
Seniors	14%
Disabled adults	10%
Able-bodied adults, no dependents	7%

Howard 2023, ch. 6

Food: charity and business are in the net

- **Feeding America:** 200 food banks, 60,000 pantries and kitchens
- **40 million** people, about **100 meals** each a year
- Walmart: **\$11 billion** in SNAP sales (2018)
- 250,000 retailers take SNAP

Howard 2023, ch. 6

Food: is it enough?

14.3 million households food insecure (2018): **one in nine**

- Most of them are **above** the poverty line
- **44%** get nothing from SNAP, WIC, or school meals
- Black households **21.2%** · Hispanic **16.2%** · White **8.1%**

Howard 2023, ch. 6, table 6.1

Housing: the expensive one

Renter households under \$15,000	
Spend over half their income on housing	70%

For every **100** extremely low-income households:

38 affordable, available units · California: **23**

Howard 2023, ch. 7

Housing: help is rationed

Program	Size
Public housing	1 million units · \$7 billion
Vouchers (Section 8)	2 million vouchers · \$20–25 billion
Tax credit for developers (LIHTC)	About 100,000 units a year · \$10 billion

About **5 million** households helped. Most who qualify get nothing.

Howard 2023, ch. 7

Housing: who gets the big subsidy?

Homeowner tax breaks	
Mortgage interest and property tax deductions	\$100 billion a year before 2017
Share to filers under \$40,000 (2019)	Under 1%

Net worth at 65+, lowest income quartile:

Owner \$105,000 · Renter \$1,000

Howard 2023, ch. 7

Housing: is it enough?

- **567,715** homeless on one night (2019)
- More than a **quarter** of them in California
- Black Americans: **13%** of the population, **40%** of the homeless
- **79 million** adults in shared households

Howard 2023, ch. 7, table 7.1

Three parts of one net

	Income	Food	Housing
Who qualifies	Workers	Anyone in need	In need, if there's money
Who pays	Workers; the affluent	The affluent	The affluent
Who delivers	Agencies, the IRS	Grocers, charities, schools	Landlords, developers
Enough?	38 million poor	14.3 million households insecure	70% of the poorest renters pay over half

Howard 2023, chs. 5–7

Due Friday: source and claims memo

One page, two columns

Column A	Column B
What I can support	What I am still assuming
Claim + the source you read	Claim you believe but have not checked

- At least **six claims** in all
- One or two sentences: what you still need to find
- **5%** · Canvas · Fri 10/9, 11:59 p.m.

The memo: talk it through first

Attach proof of **one** conversation. Any of these counts:

1. **Policy Brief Scaffold** in PapyrusAI: download the transcript
2. **Writing Center**: the confirmation email
3. **Me**: office hours, or email your draft columns

AI: Yellow. A source an AI found goes in Column B until you read it.

Try one now

Column A: one claim about your program from today, with Howard as the source

Column B: one thing you believe about your program and have not checked

3 minutes, with a neighbor

By 2:15 you should be able to say

Cash follows work. Food follows need. Housing follows the budget.

Wednesday: Medicaid, and what happens when the states decide